

Positive Emotions

Emotions

Emotions are part of being human. In fact, when we are unable to feel emotions, either good or bad, doctors or professionals try to understand why and to intervene. An emotion can be defined as a 'psychological state defined by subjective feelings but also characteristic patterns of physiological arousal thought and behaviors' (Peterson, 2006: 73).

Emotions tend to focus on a specific event or circumstance during the past, present or future. However, emotions are likely to be short lived and we are aware of them at the time of occurrence.

Moods, on the other hand, are different from emotions as they are 'free floating or objectless', more long-lasting and occupy the background consciousness' (Fredrickson and Losada, 2005: 121). Thus moods, unlike emotions, tend to be unfocused and enduring.

Traditionally, psychologists have focused on treating negative emotions or states such as anxiety and depression. Negative emotions can have extremely harmful effects on our bodies and our minds. So, of course, psychologists assume that by focusing on reducing negative emotions, we can reduce the symptoms of negative emotions. Negative emotions can cause serious problems if they are prolonged, extreme, or inappropriate in a given context.

/What happens when a person experiences chronic stress? It can cause stress-related diseases (i.e. heart disease) and compromise immune functioning, making them vulnerable to developing other types of diseases (i.e. cancers).

When psychologists began studying emotions, they focused on the term '**hedonic capacity**', which refers to our ability to feel good (Meehl, 1975). Today, researchers focus on '**affectivity**',

which is defined as 'the extent to which an individual experiences positive/negative moods' (Peterson, 2006: 62).

/Positive affect is the extent to which someone experiences joy, contentment, and so on, whereas negative affect is the extent to which someone experiences feelings such as sadness or fear.

According to Fredrickson (2000), positive emotions can, in a sense, undo negative emotions. In other words, they can weaken the effect negative emotions have on a person's body and mind. Positive emotions may help improve a person's cognition, attention, and action as well as their intellectual, social, and physical abilities.

Joy may help speed one's recovery from the cardiovascular effects caused by negative emotions.

Psychologists have developed several different techniques to help increase positive emotions and coping strategies including:

- Behavioral therapies to help increase pleasant activities
- Cognitive therapies that teach optimism
- Relaxation therapies
- Coping strategies that focus on finding positive meaning

But then along came Martin Seligman, a former American Psychological Association (APA) president. He thought that perhaps a person's life could be improved not by relieving negative emotions but by increasing positive emotions. This gave rise to a relatively new field of psychology -- positive psychology.

Given the significant role the positive emotions play in our life and happiness; we need to focus on conducting research in this area.

The mission of positive psychology is to understand and foster the factors that allow individuals, communities, and societies to flourish (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000).

What role do positive emotions play in this mission? On first consideration, the answer seems simple: Positive emotions serve as markers of flourishing, or optimal well-being.

/Certainly moments in people's lives characterized by experiences of positive emotions—such as joy, interest, contentment, love, and the like—are moments in which they are not cause by sufferings of negative emotions—such as anxiety, sadness, anger, and despair

Importance of Positive Emotions

Positive Emotions refer to the pleasant or desirable responses to the situations ranging from emotions like joy, contentment, interest, gratitude, love etc. Positive emotions also indicate absence of negative emotions like hate, anger, disgust, fear etc. Positive emotions are capable of producing optimal functioning in an individual not just momentarily but for longer period of time. Positive emotions essentially play a very significant role in our lives. Hence, we must work towards cultivating positive emotions in us and also promoting in those among other people around us. Experiencing positive emotions means to achieve and improve physical and psychological health and thereby greater life satisfaction.

By this point, we know that positive emotions impact our well-being, but what else can we say about the importance of positive emotions? By now, we know emotions can impact almost every area of our lives.

Feel-good, do-good phenomenon: the idea that when we feel good, we tend to be good. When we feel good, we do good. When we do good, we feel good!

- Pathologizing does not move us closer to the prevention of serious disorders.
 - There is a set of human strengths that are the most likely buffers against mental illness: courage, optimism, interpersonal skills, work ethic, hope honesty and determination. Much of the task of prevention will be to create a science of human strength whose mission will be to foster these virtues in young people.
 - Brain has left the mental health professions ill equipped to do effective prevention. We need massive research on human strength and virtue.
 - We need practitioners to recognize that much of the best work they can do is amplifying the strengths rather than repairing their patients' weaknesses.
- /• Although other sub areas of psychology were not focused on human weaknesses, 20th century applied psychology and psychiatry typically were. For example, consider the statement attributed to Sigmund Freud that the goal of Psychology should be "to replace neurotic misery with ordinary unhappiness".

Science is helping us find out how valuable positive emotions can be. Experts have learned a lot from recent brain studies. Here are two findings that can help us use positive emotions to our advantage:

1. Let Positive Emotions Outnumber Negative Ones

When we feel more positive emotions than negative ones, difficult situations are easier to handle. Positive emotions build our resilience (the emotional resources needed for coping). They broaden our awareness, letting us see more options for problem solving.

Studies show that people feel and do their best when they have at least three times as many positive emotions as negative emotions. /That's because of something called the negativity bias. The negativity bias is a natural human tendency to pay

more attention to negative emotions than to positive ones. It makes sense when you think about it: Negative emotions call our attention to problems — problems we might need to deal with quickly. Tuning in to negative emotions can be a survival mechanism.

2. Practice Positivity Every Day

Building habits that encourage us to feel more positive emotions can help us be happier, do better, and reduce our negative emotions. Building positive emotions is especially important if we're already dealing with a lot of negative feelings such as fear, sadness, anger, frustration, or stress.

Building a daily positivity habit is pretty simple. It comes down to two basic steps:

1. **Notice and name** your positive emotions. Start by simply focusing on your feelings. You can tune in to your emotions in real time, as they happen. Or take stock at the end of the day, noting how you felt in different situations. For example, you might feel proud when you answer a question right, joyful when your puppy chases you around the yard, or loved when your mom shows up at your game. When you first start doing this, you'll probably need to remind yourself to focus on your emotions. But — like any habit — it gets easier the more you do it.
2. **Pick an emotion and act to increase it.** Let's say you choose confidence: What helps you feel confident? How can you get more of that feeling? You might give yourself a **"Yes, I can!"** pep talk before a test (a short speech that is given to encourage someone to work harder, to feel more confident and enthusiastic, etc.). Or maybe you stand up straighter and practice walking through the halls in a confident way, feeling strong and powerful.

/The Importance of Positive Emotions for Wellbeing

Experiencing our own and other's positive emotions (for example, sharing joy) reinforces connections that "lead to many positive outcomes, for example, subjective wellbeing, lesser negative affect, greater trust, and better relationship quality" (Paakkanen et al., 2021, p. 2).

Therefore, positive emotions indirectly benefit wellbeing, supporting the building and maintaining of solid relationships. There are direct impacts too. Positivity can improve psychological and physiological wellbeing "by cultivating experiences of positive emotions at opportune moments to cope with negative emotions" (Fredrickson, 2001, p. 222).

5+ Benefits of Being Positive

The effects of positive emotions are widespread, and their benefits are seen across multiple areas of our lives.

At work

"As an integral part of feeling and strengthening social connection, expressions of positive emotions at work can benefit the individual expressing them as well as the coworkers, the customers, and the entire organization" (Paakkanen et al., 2021, p. 2).

The nature of reactions to such expressions is vital. Asymmetrical responses — for example, a lack of positive recognition — can harm the volume of positive emotions experienced and relationship quality. It seems empathy has a part to play in responding to a coworker's positive experiences and feelings (Paakkanen et al., 2021).

Ultimately, if the experience of positive emotions is not tempered, such pleasurable emotional states can be a significant factor in supporting wellbeing. In a 2021 study involving teachers, positive

emotions were the most predictive factor in job satisfaction and staff retention (Dreer, 2021).

For your mental health

The experience of positive emotions predicts decreased symptoms of depression and a lowering of perceived stress. In fact, research shows an association between negative emotions and poorer mental health (Tugade et al., 2014).

However, it is essential to note that the size of such effects does appear to vary across cultures (Tugade et al., 2014).

The beneficial effect of positive emotions on our wellbeing is perhaps unsurprising. "Positive emotions motivate us to pursue important goals, allow us to savor important experiences, and reinforce adaptive behavior patterns" (Tugade et al., 2014, p. 432). All of which, according to positive psychology's PERMA model (along with engagement, positive relationships, meaning, and achievement) have a favorable effect on our wellbeing (Seligman, 2011).

To relieve stress

While the experience of positive emotions is vital to managing and relieving stress, so too is its timing (Tugade et al., 2014). Stress is often experienced during times of change or transition, for example, moving to a new house, changing jobs, or welcoming a new baby. When we experience such change, positive emotions can decrease the impact of the stressor (Tugade et al., 2014).

Positive emotion interventions, often combined with mindfulness practices, have been shown to improve quality of life and decrease symptoms of stress (Tugade et al., 2014).

Emotions such as joy, curiosity, and hope are vital counterparts to stress, which is often seen as the quantity and quality of negative emotions (Dreer, 2021). Indeed, it seems that positive emotions can lead employees to seek out increased work

engagement and heighten their readiness to face new challenges, which ultimately benefit their stress response (Wang, 2022).

For strong relationships

As we have already seen, positive emotions are helpful in bond formation (Fredrickson, 2010).

“Strong emotional experiences are part and parcel of close relationships” (Tugade et al., 2014, p. 215). They have the potential to motivate the initial engagement (romantic or otherwise), solidify commitment, and protect the relationship from external threats.

In line with the broaden-and-build theory, positive emotions help us pursue opportunities to form relationships to the fullest, process more information from the environment, and expand our focus to include our partner’s perspective (Tugade et al., 2014).

For creativity

Fredrickson’s broaden-and-build theory also predicts the beneficial effect of positive emotions on creativity, and it’s confirmed by research.

“Positive emotions allow an individual to process information from the environment in more global, innovative, flexible, and creative ways” (Tugade et al., 2014, p. 218). Faster recovery from negative emotions and their associated stressors and greater resilience supports the continuation of creativity.

Studies with educators have shown that positive emotions increase creativity along with many other benefits (Dreer, 2021).

Why are positive emotions useful in a classroom?

Research shows that focusing on positive emotions has a range of benefits, including:

- broadened ideas or activities
- improved performance-related outcomes

- improved general wellbeing
- decreased feelings of stress
- reduced negative emotions.

By encouraging positive emotions among your students, you will assist them to be more focused and achieve better learning outcomes. Most importantly, they will also build their resilience, which will have a positive impact on their overall wellbeing.

Determinants of subjective well-being

Happiness: The Science of Subjective Well-Being

Subjective well-being (SWB) is the scientific term for happiness and life satisfaction—thinking and feeling that your life is going well, not badly. Scientists rely primarily on self-report surveys to assess the happiness of individuals, but they have validated these scales with other types of measures. People's levels of subjective well-being are influenced by both internal factors, such as personality and outlook, and external factors, such as the society in which they live.

Some of the major determinants of subjective well-being are age, gender, money, work satisfaction, social support, faith, self-esteem, etc.

Importantly, researchers have also studied the outcomes of subjective well-being and have found that "happy" people are more likely to be healthier and live longer, to have better social relationships, and to be more productive at work compared to people who are chronically stressed, depressed, or angry. Thus, happiness does not just feel good, but it is good for people and for those around them.

Age:

Repeated surveys across the world reveal that no time of life is notably happiest and most satisfying. Myers asks an interesting question: do funds, friends, or faith predict happiness? Although many people believe there are unhappy times of life—times of adolescent stress, midlife crisis, or old age decline—repeated. Surveys across the industrialized world reveal that no time of life is notably happiest and most satisfying (Myers & Diener, 1995). Emotionality changes with maturity and the predictors of happiness change (later in life, satisfaction with social relations and health become more important). Yet, in every age group there are many happy and some unhappy people.

Gender:

Like age, gender gives little clue to happiness. Despite the well-known gender gaps in misery—men more often act antisocial or become alcoholic, women more often ruminate and get depressed or anxious. Men and women are equally likely to declare themselves "very happy" and "satisfied" with their lives. This conclusion is grounded in surveys of 170,000 adults in 16 countries (Inglehart, 1990), in surveys of 18,000 university students in 39 countries (Michalos, 1991), and in a meta-analysis of 146 other studies (Haring, Stock, & Okun, 1984).

Money/ Wealth

"Could money buy you happiness?" Most people will deny it. However, ask a different question "Would a little more money make you a little happier?" and many will smile and nod yes. What would improve their quality of life? "More money," was the most frequent response to a University of Michigan national survey (Campbell, 1981), and the more the better. In a study by Gallup Poll (Gallup & Newport, 1990) it was concluded that 1 in 2

women, 2 in 3 men, and 4 in 5 people earning more than \$75,000 reported they would like to be rich.

Are Rich People Happier?

According to the research of Diener (2000), There is some tendency for wealthy nations to have more satisfied people. However, national wealth is entangled with civil rights, literacy, and the number of continuous years of democracy, which make it difficult to separate the effects of other variables from the impact of money on well-being.

Life Satisfaction across Nations

Nation	Life Satisfaction
Bulgaria	5.03
Russia	5.37
Hungary	6.03
Turkey	6.41
Japan	6.53
Korea (South)	6.69
India	6.70
Portugal	7.07
Pakistan	7.07*
Germany	7.22
China	7.29
Italy	7.30
Finland	7.68
United States	7.73
Netherlands	7.77
Canada	7.89
Switzerland	8.36

* Findings drawn from a Pakistani survey (Suhail & Chaudhry, 2002)

In comparison with other nations, Pakistani people lie more or less at the median point (7.11) on the scale of life satisfaction. Pakistani people are less happy than majority of the European and North American countries, and are happier than previous Soviet Union, some Eastern European and Asian countries. It can be inferred from the ratings shown in the table that the affluent nations with economic and political stability are conducive to increased satisfaction with life. Diener et al. (1995) suggested that one reason for wealthy nations for being happier is that they are more likely to fulfil basic human needs for food, shelter and health. Also they have better human-rights records. Japan appears as an exception with high income and relatively low level of well being. Diener (2000) suggested that this unexpected finding might be due to strong conformity pressures and very high expectations.

What factors then predict Happiness?

Work Satisfaction

About 50% of the variation in current happiness is heritable. Like cholesterol levels, happiness is genetically influenced but not genetically fixed.

Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi (1990, 1999) has observed increased quality of life when work and leisure engage one's skills. Between the anxieties of being overwhelmed and the apathy of being underwhelmed and bored lies a zone in which people experience what Csikszentmihalyi terms flow. People report greatest enjoyment not when mindlessly passive but when unselfconsciously absorbed in a mindful challenge.

In a Pakistani survey (Suhail & Chaudhry, 2004), work satisfaction appeared to be the best predictors of life satisfaction and personal happiness. The famous Russian writer Maksim Gorky anticipated recent research on work satisfaction by demonstrating that 'when work is pleasure life is a joy and when work is duty life is slavery'. This satisfaction seems to be driven less by the external monetary rewards than by the intrinsic rewards of creating the work and finding personal identity (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990).

Social support

Friendships and Well-Being

Francis Bacon (1625) believed "Being attached to friends and partners with whom we can share intimate thoughts has two effects:

- It redoubleth joys, and
- Cutteth griefs in half."

When asked by the National Opinion Research Center, "How many close friends would you say you have?" (excluding family members), 26% of those reporting fewer than five friends and 38% of those reporting five or more friends said they were "very happy". Those who enjoy close relationships cope better with various stresses, including bereavement, rape, job loss, and illness. Among 800 college alumni surveyed, those who preferred a high income and occupational success and prestige to having very close friends and a close marriage-were twice as likely as their former classmates to describe themselves as "fairly" or "very" unhappy (Perkins, 1991).

Faith and Well-being

Religiously active people also report somewhat higher levels of happiness (Inglehart, 1990). National Opinion Research Center surveys reveal higher levels of happiness in religious people as results showed "very happy" people among those who feel "extremely close to God" (41%) rather than "somewhat close" (29%) or "not close" or "unbelieving" (23%).

Why a positive correlation between religiosity and happiness:

- A partial explanation seems to be that faith communities provide social support.
- Another reason is the sense of meaning and purpose that many people derive from their faith. Seligman (1988) has contended that a loss of meaning feeds today's high depression rate, finding

meaning requires an attachment to something larger than the lonely self. To the extent that young people now find it hard to take seriously their relationship with God, to care about their relationship with the country or to be part of a large and abiding family, they will find it very difficult to find meaning in life.

- Faith also proposes answers to "the terror resulting from our awareness of vulnerability and death."

self-esteem?

Self-esteem is the opinion we have of ourselves.

When we have healthy self-esteem, we tend to feel positive about ourselves and about life in general. It makes us better able to deal with life's ups and downs.

When our self-esteem is low, we tend to see ourselves and our life in a more negative and critical light. We also feel less able to take on the challenges that life throws at us.

According to the American Psychological Association, having high self-esteem is key to positive mental health and well-being. High self-esteem is good because it helps you develop coping skills, handle adversity, and put the negative into perspective.

If you have a higher self-concept you also don't tend to put undue focus, blame, self-doubt, hopelessness, or weight on the parts you aren't happy about. You're also better able to cope with stress, anxiety, and pressure, whether from school, work, home, or peers.

Conclusions:

- Happiness depends less on exterior things than most suppose
- Happiness is a rich mix of reasonable wealth, social support, faith, purpose, and meaning in life

- There is a need to rethink our priorities and envision a world that enhances human well-being

Positive Emotions & Physical Health

The research by Sheldon Cohen, Ph.D., of Carnegie Mellon University and colleagues adds to a body of literature that suggests that **emotional styles influence health**. The researchers interviewed 334 healthy volunteers by phone for 7 evenings over 3 weeks to assess their emotional states. **Participants described how they felt throughout the day in three positive-emotion areas of strength/energy, well-being and calm and three negative-emotion areas of depression, anxiety and hostility by rating their emotions on a scale of 0 to 4.** After this initial evaluation, researchers administered a shot of a rhinovirus, the germ that causes colds, into each participant's nose. Afterward, participants were observed for 5 days to see if they became sick and in what ways cold symptoms manifested. The volunteers were considered to have a clinical cold if they were both infected and met illness criteria.

"People who scored low on positive emotional style were three times more likely to get sick than those with high positive emotional styles," Cohen says. **The researchers then measured how emotional style affected all sick participants' reporting of cold symptoms.** Each day of the **quarantine**, researchers asked them to **report the severity of such cold symptoms as a runny nose, cough, and headaches on a 4-point scale.** While negative emotional style did not affect whether people developed colds, the study found that people with **higher negative emotional styles reported more symptoms than expected from objective health markers,** Cohen says. **Positive emotional style was also**

associated with better health practices and lower levels of neither epinephrine, nor epinephrine and cortisol, three stress-related hormones, but the researchers found that this did not account for the link between positive emotional style and illness.

